BETTING BIG ON DATA

How Gati Shakti and the National Logistics Policy are putting India's infra on a high growth trajectory

The Centre's Gati Shakti plan aims to bring all government ministries together and streamline the planning of projects. **Sumita Dawra**, Special Secretary (Logistics), talks about the ambitious project and how India plans to improve its logistics performance.

TRACKING OUR ASSETS

Gati Shakti is a tool for infrastructure planning. It brings together all government departments and states on a GIS platform and, today, we have over 1,400 data layers on it. The infra assets of the railway ministry, the road ministry, ports, shipping and renewable energy, power and telecom are all mapped on the platform. Also, social infrastructure such as schools, anganwadi centres, hospitals—you name it, they are all mapped. Similarly, natural resources, forest areas, wildlife sanctuaries. What happens is easy visualisation of the data layers that are needed for planning.

DEMAND-LED APPROACH

The National Logistics Policy has a target of taking India's logistics performance among the top 25 countries in the world by 2030.

Another intervention is the Logistics Data Bank, which is also mentioned by the World Bank in its latest Logistic Performance Index Report 2023. It tracks the exim (export-import) containers of the country a 100 per cent. Sixty million containers have been traced in the last six years. This big data analytics is powering reform today.

There is a lot of data coming in and we are now seeing how we can utilise it better. China has done a supply-led model to infra development. We are looking at a demand-led approach. We can better predict where we need the next highway, the next augmentation of the railway line, and so on. ■

> "Through Gati Shakti, what happens is easy visualisation of the data layers that are needed for planning.... There is a lot of data coming in and we are now seeing how we can utilise it better for a demand-led approach to infra development"
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> **SUMITA DAWRA**
> Special Secretary (Logistics)



In 2020, the Narendra Modi government launched the National Infrastructure Pipeline, aimed at boosting India's infrastructure with a capital outlay of Rs 100 lakh crore by 2025. The 2023 budget gave a huge boost to capital spending by providing Rs 10 lakh crore, a 33 per cent increase from the previous year. Three top experts, **Vinayak Chatterjee** of Infravision Foundation, **Manish R. Sharma** of PwC and L&T's **K.V.B. Reddy**, assess the challenges ahead.

BANG FOR THE BUCK

Vinayak Chatterjee: After the last budget, INDIA TODAY had that roundtable with the finance secretaries and the people who made the budget. A very significant comment was made by the seniormost bureaucrat in the finance ministry. He said they have a confidential report—the government had found out that one rupee spent on infrastructure resulted in 3 rupees of GDP. Whereas one rupee spent on direct benefit transfer resulted in 90 paisa of GDP. So, the math is clear, where do you get bang for the buck is clear. The government has stuck to that rule of pumping in big money in public expenditure under that mantra. This was done on a consistent basis with a 30-35 per cent increase in central budgetary outlays year after year after year.

REAL ESTATE QUAGMIRE

Manish R. Sharma: A project,when it comes up, will raise the value of real estate. But what we do is bundle the real estate into the PPP. So, lenders who are comfortable with an infrastructure risk and will look at a 9 per cent borrowing and lending rate, suddenly see the real estate being a larger part of the portfolio of revenue, and will start looking at it as a real estate project and not an infrastructure